DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

# Justice or Unity: Two Ways God Runs the World

Daat Tevunot §134-138

**Sefer:** Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §134-138
**Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Tuesday 20 June 2023

*These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.*

## A new topic

After a week of revision, the class returned to the text in Section 7. The Rabbi set out the shape of the book: Section 1 is the introduction, Section 2 the Yihud of Hashem, Section 3 goes into more detail, Section 4 is body and soul, and Sections 5 and 6 are about how evil was created and what it is for. Sections 7, 8 and 9 deal with how Hashem runs the world, and this will be the focus "for the next few months".

## We do not affect Hashem Himself

The paragraph opens (§134) with a principle. When we say a person does good or bad "to Hashem", none of it affects Hashem Himself. As the verse says, "if you sin, what do you do to Him? If you are righteous, what do you give Him?"

Hashem created a system of laws. When people keep them, good comes out of it, and when they break them, bad comes out. That is what it means when the Torah speaks of a "pleasing aroma" or of a misvah giving "strength" to Hashem. Our deeds do not touch Him. They affect the system He has set up. Good deeds strengthen it and are called Hashem's glory. Bad deeds weaken it and are called desecration. "Obviously you're not desecrating Hashem Himself, because you can't."

## The analogy of a father's rules

The Rabbi called this "really important" and gave an analogy. A father sets up a system at home: do this and you will be rewarded, do that and something will be taken away. Once the child acts, the father has to follow the system he made, because that is the deal. In that sense he has bound himself to it.

Hashem has done the same. He made a system with consequences for good and bad and, as it were, bound Himself to follow it, "99.9% of the time". But a father can always say: "I'm in charge here. I'm suspending the whole system." A participant suggested the word "sovereignty", and the Rabbi said that is exactly what the Ramhal will call it later.

## Two modes

So there are two hanhagot, two modes:

1. **The mode of good and bad,** or reward and punishment (hanhagat hamishpat). Hashem reacts to what we do. Out of it come sekhar veonesh, teshuvah, atonement through suffering in this world, and consequences in the next world.
2. **The deeper mode** that guides all of existence to its final perfection, the tikkun hashalem, in which all bad will eventually be banished. This mode works from the background, out of Hashem's concealment and His eventual revealing of Himself.

The Rabbi put the difference in one line: "One is reactive, one is proactive." The first responds to our deeds. The second drives everything towards its goal whatever we do, and it is behind what is called acting "beyond the letter of the law". The first is the one that is usually evident, and the one that runs throughout the Torah.

On the words "reward and punishment", the Rabbi repeated something he said in earlier shiurim on the Rambam. He does not like the phrase. It is better to speak of consequences, positive and negative, which bring a person closer to Hashem or further away.

## Setting mode two aside

In §135-136 the Ramhal says that both modes need explaining, at least their principles, since there would be no end to the details. He will begin with the first, because it is more evident to us. The Neshamah answers: "Speak, for I am listening."

## Two foundations "which are three"

In §138 the Sekhel lays out the foundations of the first mode. The Rabbi compared this to a good teacher who states the learning objective at the start of a lesson. There are two categories "which are really three":

1. **How Hashem acts on the world:** He watches and judges everything that happens and sends His emanations accordingly.
2. **An offshoot of this:** the judgment comes from love, so it is never too harsh. "As a father chastises his son, so Hashem your God chastises you." Punishment is not hostility. Someone who spares the rod does not love his child. So Hashem's chastisement is sweetened and not cruel, and sometimes He leaves the throne of justice for the throne of mercy.
3. **How we are affected:** how these actions reach us personally as individuals.

The Rabbi went back to the father. To run the home, he must always know what the child is doing, even when the child thinks he is alone. That is category one. How each act then affects the child is category two. And because it all comes from love, even a negative judgment is never cruel. That is the offshoot.

There was some confusion among the participants about which category the "ripple effects" belong to. The Rabbi said he would go over it again on Thursday.

## Summary

- Our deeds do not affect Hashem Himself. They affect the system of laws He created, which He has, as it were, bound Himself to follow.
- There are two modes: the reactive mode of justice and consequences, and the proactive mode that leads everything to the final tikkun.
- Hashem can override the system, like a father suspending his own house rules. This will be discussed in later sections.
- Within the mode of justice there are two categories: how Hashem acts on the world, and how we receive it.
- Because judgment flows from love, it is always softened. "As a father chastises his son."

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